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Section Title(S)

KINSHIP AND THE NAME RELATION • MARRIAGE

This principle is extended widely, so that a person with ego's father's name is treated "like father," bearers of ego's mother's name are "like mother," and bearers of ego's siblings' names are "like brother and sister." It is important for the !Kung to use a kinship term for every person they meet, since the term defines whether a person is in the joking or avoidance category. In establishing a relation with a newcomer or a person at a distant camp, the older of the pair has the right to specify the terms used. He chooses a kin term that he applies to a member of his own kindred with the same name as the newcomer. If no common basis of association can be found, he may turn to his affines or to his sibling's affines to see if the other shares a name with any one of them. With 70 percent of the population using only twenty of the sixty-nine personal names in use,¹⁰ it is almost always possible for a person to establish kinship with another even if he comes from a far distant camp. In fact, there are usually several possible name routes from one person to another. This ambiguity is useful to the !Kung in keeping the kinship system flexible in the face of frequent changes in group structure.

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MARRIAGE

The far-reaching ties made possible by the name relation are of particular importance in the arrangement of marriages. The !Kung Bushmen are unusual among hunter-gatherers in that they extend the incest taboo collaterally and forbid marriages between actual cousins. This prohibition sends the young men (and women) far afield when seeking a spouse.

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A young man has a wide range of potential spouses to choose from. In addition to his immediate female relatives as far as second cousins, a man may *not* marry a girl with the same name as his mother, his sister, or in the case of second marriages, the same name as his daughter or his mother-in-law. Similarly, a girl may not marry a man whose name is the same as her father, her brother, her son, or her father-in-law. All others not excluded  358 by reason of blood or name-sharing kinship are potential spouses for ego if they are of a suitable age.

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10. Because of differential reproduction, some of the names are far more popular than others. Eight of the men's names have ten or more holders each, while eleven other names each have only one holder in the population.

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